

Exchange Online Practice Notes

Service Desk Analyst – Hands-on Summary

1. Overview

Exchange Online is Microsoft's cloud email system. It is part of Microsoft 365. These notes cover the main tasks a Tier 1 Service Desk analyst performs with Exchange Online.

2. Platforms We Used

Microsoft 365 Admin Center

Main place to manage users, licenses, and groups. This is usually the starting point for most Service Desk work.

Exchange Admin Center

Used for email-specific tasks: mailboxes, shared mailboxes, distribution lists, mail flow rules, and message trace.

Microsoft Entra (entra.microsoft.com)

Identity platform. Manages users, groups, roles, and permissions across Microsoft 365 and Azure.

3. Setting Up the Lab

We used a free Microsoft 365 Business Basic 1-month trial. This gave us a real Exchange Online environment to practice safely without affecting a production system.

The trial includes Microsoft 365 admin center containing end-user apps (Microsoft 365 Copilot, Outlook, OneDrive, Word, Excel, PowerPoint, OneNote, SharePoint, Teams, Viva, Bookings for scheduling, Admin) and admin-centric apps containing Security for Cyber blue team, Microsoft Purview for data governance, data security, and compliance, Exchange, SharePoint, Teams and Power Platform.

4. Creating Users

Steps:

1. Go to Microsoft 365 Admin Center → Users → Active users
2. Click Add a user
3. Enter name and email address

4. Assign a license
5. Finish the wizard

Note: When you create a user and assign a license that includes Exchange, a mailbox is created automatically.

5. Shared Mailbox

A shared mailbox is used by multiple people (for example, a Service Desk inbox). It does not need its own license.

What we did:

- Created a shared mailbox called “Service Desk”
- Added an alias (help desk)
- Gave Read and manage (Full Access) to admin and Send As permissions to newly created service desk people
- Tested sending and receiving emails from the shared mailbox

6. Distribution List

A distribution list is used to send one email to many people at the same time.

What we did:

- Teams & groups > Active teams > Distribution list (tab)
- Created a distribution list called VAPT
- Added users as members
- Sent a test email to the group address and confirmed members received it

7. Mail Flow Rule

Mail flow rules evaluate messages in transit before they reach the inbox. They apply logic based on conditions, actions, and exceptions.

What we did:

- Created a rule that blocks emails from outside the organization
- Set the action to reject the message and include an explanation
- Tested the rule — external emails were blocked successfully

Review and finish

After your finish creating this rule, it is turned off by default until you turn it on from the Rules page

Rule name

Accept_from_Domain

Rule comments

Rule conditions

Apply this rule if

The sender is located 'NotInOrganization'

Do the following

Reject the message with the explanation 'Out of your organization'

Except if

[Edit rule conditions](#)

Rule settings

Mode

Enforce

Set date range

7/30/2026 02:00 -

Priority

0

Severity

Not specified

For rule processing errors

Ignore

[Back](#)

[Finish](#)

8. Message Trace

Message Trace shows the path of an email and why it was delivered, delayed, or blocked. This is one of the most useful tools for Service Desk when a user says "I didn't receive the email."

We ran a Mail flow > Message trace and confirmed the blocked email appeared in results with 'Failed' status.

Message trace search results

↓ Export results	✎ Edit message trace	🔄 Refresh	📄 View in Explorer	1 item	🔍 Filter	🔍 Search	☰	🔗 Find related
✓ Date (UTC-06:00) ↓	Sender	Recipient	Subject	Status				
✓ 7/30/2026, 2:37 AM	[REDACTED]	[REDACTED]	mal...	Failed				

9. Connecting to Exchange Online with PowerShell

We tried to use PowerShell to manage Exchange Online.

First attempt – Azure Cloud Shell

Opened Cloud Shell from the Microsoft 365 or Azure portal.

Ran:

```
PowerShellConnect-ExchangeOnline -Device
```

Cloud Shell gave a link and a code (this is normal for device authentication).

After signing in, "you don't have access to this" appeared.

Even after assigning the Exchange Administrator role in Entra (entra.microsoft.com → Roles and administrators), Cloud Shell continued to fail.

Working solution – Local Windows PowerShell

Because Cloud Shell was unreliable, we switched to local PowerShell on a Windows machine:

Install the module:

```
PowerShellInstall-Module -Name ExchangeOnlineManagement -Scope CurrentUser -Force
```

Connect:

```
PowerShellConnect-ExchangeOnline -UserPrincipalName  
youradmin@yourdomain.onmicrosoft.com
```

This method worked reliably.

Important notes

Some PowerShell commands only work with on-premises Exchange Server. Some only work with Exchange Online. A few work in both environments. Always check the official documentation to confirm which commands apply to Exchange Online:

Takeaway for Service Desk

Most day-to-day Tier 1 work is done in the GUI (Microsoft 365 Admin Center and Exchange Admin Center). PowerShell is useful for bulk tasks or automation, but it is not required for basic support.

9. Key Differences to Remember

- **User mailbox:** Belongs to one person and needs a license.
- **Shared mailbox:** Used by several people. No separate license required (under normal limits).
- **Distribution list:** Only used for sending emails to a group of people.

10. Common Service Desk Tasks

These are the main Exchange-related tasks a Tier 1 analyst usually handles:

- Create or confirm a user account
- Assign the correct license
- Make sure the mailbox works
- Add the user to the right groups or distribution lists
- Grant access to shared mailboxes when needed
- Help with basic email delivery problems using Message Trace
- Support offboarding (disable account, convert mailbox, remove licenses, etc.)

11. Summary

We practiced the core Exchange Online skills needed for a Service Desk Analyst role using the Microsoft 365 and Exchange Admin Center. The focus was on real day-to-day tasks rather than advanced administration.